JOAN'S IN TOWN

written by

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FADE IN:

EXT. WOODS - DAY

A waxy hand sticks out of a freshly covered make-shift grave. The sun reflects off a gem on one of the fingers, the fourth.

JOAN (V.O.)
I wonder who gave her that.
(beat)
Too bad they'll never get to see it again, along with her body.

JOAN, 20s, with stains of all sorts on her, pats the dirt with her shovel. The people next to her do the same thing. Joan wipes the sweat off of her forehead before looking up, to which her eyes meet another's.

There's something watching her. Someone. A girl. She wasn't even trying to hide herself, clearly looking right at Joan. Joan drops her shovel and musters up the courage to move closer.

JOAN
(screaming)
Hey!

The girl begins to walk away. Joan follows. Eventually, after a minute or so of following to no avail, the girl pauses. She turns around to face Joan. Joan squints, trying to identify her face. She cannot.

JOAN
You can't be here.

The girl steps forward.

JOAN
Why were you looking at me? Who are you?

The girl takes another step towards her. Joan is concerned while the girl seems almost relieved.

MYSTERIOUS FIGURE
(whispering)
Joan!

JOAN
How do you know my name?

A loud crash sounds in the distance. It came from behind ESSIE, 20s, whose soft features make her look like an angel. We cut to a road separating the woods from a nearby farmland. As a matter of fact, it might be where Essie walked over from.

ESSIE
I'm sorry. It's time for me to go.

Essie begins to walk in the direction of the road. There are no barriers surrounding the woods; Joan could follow her if she wanted to--and she does just that.

JOAN
Wait!

Joan follows Essie, quickening her pace before. All of a sudden, Essie turns. Her angelic aura disappears. We see a sickening closeup shot of her face, and she begins to scream terrifyingly. It is so loud, you can visibly see the veins in Essie's neck as her vocal cords slam together. The skin on her face breaks into jagged square fragments, glitching.

The road starts to warp itself, turning a pulsing dark shade of red. Behind her, the trees do the same. Joan doesn't know what to do. She tries to cover her ears as the screaming continues when multiple hands grab at her, pulling her back towards the forest. Now, Joan screams.

CUT TO:

EXT. COMMONS - DAY

Joan wakes up in a jolt, picking her head off a wooden table. To the left of her are two girls. They have straw-like crowns and white ankle-length satin dresses on. Joan is dressed the same, though her crown is more like angular, almost paper-boat shaped. PARIS, 20s, turns to Joan, holding a hand-made paint brush made out of grass.

PARIS
(to Joan)
Father Joseph is going to be upset if he sees you slacking off during craft time.

Joan struggles to remember when she fell asleep. Her dream, vision, or whatever it was felt so real; like she really was in that forest, and that girl or whatever that thing was wanted to tell her something.

JOAN
What time is it?

Paris looks up at the sky, then towards the woods, then raises her hand against the horizon.

PARIS
Looks like it's around 1 PM. Why?

JOAN
Nothing. Just curious.
(thinks)
Do you ever wonder what is out there?

PARIS
(chortling)
Out where? Past the Commons?

The expression on Paris's face suddenly turns stone-cold, her demeanor serious as she looks right into Joan's eyes.

PARIS
Jeez, Joan. What's got you thinking about that kinda stuff?

JOAN
Are you telling me you've never thought about it?

PARIS
Of course, I have. But I haven't thought about it since I got to Potemkin because I know what's out there. We all know what is out there.
(pause)
Sinners. The world is a dangerous place, Joan. Don't go thinking that it can offer you more than what you already have here.

Joan shifts uncomfortably in her seat. Her expression, unreadable as Paris, bores her eyes into her soul. Joan tries to look past the trees, toward the direction of the road. She quickly stops herself.

JOAN
Forget I said anything. I think I'm just tired today. I'll see you guys during Supper. I'm going to go lay down.

Joan gets up and walks away, leaving Paris behind to fiddle with her paint brush.

CUT TO:

EXT. WIDE SHOT OF THE ENTIRE COMMONS

We cut to a symbol etched into a tree. It looks like a P, but the semicircle part of it is triangular, and a diagonal line bisects the vertical line pointing northwest.

CUT TO:

EXT. JOAN'S FRONT PORCH - DAY

Joan enters her cabin with her arms crossed over themselves before turning to shut the door. Before cutting away, a bright figure dashes in front of the porch.

DISSOLVE TO:

INT. JOAN'S CABIN

Joan walks into her room, noticing how loudly the floorboards creak at every step. She sits slowly on her bed, the mattress letting out a small squeak. She's tired. She's confused. She can't stop thinking about what she saw in her dream. Nonetheless, she lies down in an attempt to forget about it.

The sound of rustling takes Joan out of her nap. Groggily, Joan gets out of bed to open and look outside her window. Nothing. When she turns around, there she is. That girl.

JOAN
What the hell!

Essie stands across from Joan with a huge, plastered grin. Her hair billows as the wind of the night picks up its speed and enters through the window.

ESSIE
(whispering)
I'm sorry if I scared you earlier.

JOAN
Listen, I don't know what you want

from me, but whatever it is, I don't have it.

Essie's smile slowly fades and her expression softens. She seems disappointed. Even then, her posture hasn't change.

ESSIE
Do you know who I am?

JOAN
No. But how do you know me? And why won't you leave me alone? Why did you scream in my face, you freak?

Essie seems visibly hurt by this statement, and Joan is noticeably agitated. Joan is even more agitated at the fact that she still cannot make out this girl's face.

Joan's face drops.

JOAN
You're one of them, aren't you?
(whispering)
One of those sinners. They disguise themselves; that's what Father Joseph says.

Essie doesn't know what Joan is talking about at first.

ESSIE
Sinners?

Essie looks down at herself then back at Joan.

ESSIE
Oh.

Joan's words cut right through her heart.

ESSIE
That's not something I can control, Joan.

JOAN
Bullshit, you're here to trick me. I'm not falling for this.

Essie stands there, silent.

JOAN
Say something. Tell me who you are.

ESSIE
You know who I am.

JOAN
No. I don't.

ESSIE
(pleading)
Yes, you do, Joan. It's me, [REDACTED].

The words that come out like distorted errors in a videogame.

Joan wakes up once more. It's getting harder to distinguish between real life and her dreams, but it can't be some kind of coincidence, right? What are the chances of her envisioning the same person twice? Maybe it is a sign. Maybe it is nothing. Something is prodding at her mind, but she can't seem to remember what. Right on cue, the bells ring.

JOAN
Shit.

It's time for Supper.

CUT TO:

EXT. COMMONS - SUNSET

A long table dressed in white linen is still being set up when Joan finally trudges over. As people start filing in, Joan takes the seat next to Paris. Hopefully, Supper can relieve Joan of her confusion for the time being.

PARIS
How was the nap, Joan of Narc?

Joan knows she's joking, but something in her voice sounded targeted, like she was really trying to piss her off. She puts on a fake smile.

JOAN
It was good, thanks.

A woman in, what it looks like, her 30s, places a plate in front of everyone. Behind her a smaller uncanny version of her, presumedly her daughter, places food on the plates. A combination of berries, nuts, and wheat. A voice comes from Joan's left.

UNNAMED GIRL
Hey, when do we get the drinks?

They must be new.

JOAN
Oh, only one of us tonight gets to drink. The rest get water in the morning.

UNNAMED GIRL
Oh, is something special happening tonight?

JOAN
Yeah, the selection for this month's Sacrest.

UNNAMED GIRL
Sacrest?

JOAN
I won't ruin the surprise, you'll see tonight.

Overhearing the conversation, Paris butts in.

PARIS
I passed by the way. The Sacrest. It's a piece of cake.

UNNAMED GIRL
Oh, so it's like a test?

Joan glares at Paris with a poker face.

PARIS
My bad, Joan. I'll keep it a surprise.

Paris goes back to chatting with her friend.

Joan turns back to her dish. Out of the corner of her eyes, she sees him. A round of applause rings through the air. FATHER JOSEPH, 60s, wearing a burgundy cassock, walks over slowly with his hands behind his back. He actually looks quite young for his age if you were to ignore the silver-streaked strands on his head.

FATHER JOSEPH
Hello, friends. We seem hungry today.

Everyone laughs.

FATHER JOSEPH
It seems everyone is very ready to dig in. You can all thank Mother Avila for preparing tonight's supper.

Father Joseph has a natural cadence to him. He always uses the right tone and diction when he speaks and demands attention without any effort. When he walks by, you can't help but turn your head to him.

FATHER JOSEPH
If you haven't noticed, we have a new friend joining us here at Potemkin.

He gestures at the grinning girl next to Joan. She waves to everyone.

FATHER JOSEPH
I hope you all treat her well and show what Potemkin has to offer.
(pause)
Alright, no more announcements. Let's eat.

The trees swallow the clinks of spoons and forks hitting plates. Loud crunches fill Joan's ear as she stabs at the hickory nuts and huckleberries with her fork.

The sound of a flute interrupts Joan mid-bite. A group of ten wearing white veils make their way around the table. Two of them are on music duty, it seems, blowing into their woodwind aerophones. The rest dance in pairs. Like a swing dance, they wrap their arms around each other, bodies twisting, turning, and spinning. Excitement engulfs the space; everyone claps along.

The fun continues until the sun is fully set. It was time for everyone to make their way to the selection grounds.

FADE TO:

EXT. SELECTION GROUNDS - NIGHT

Behind the grounds sits Father Joseph's confessional room, which also doubles as his office. Melon-sized rocks lay the border as a large circle. Each person stands behind one and holds hands. Father Joseph stands in the center. He puts on a remorseful yet stern face before delivering a speech Joan has heard plenty of times before.

FATHER JOSEPH
Let me make this known before I make the selection for tonight's Sacrest. Remember that this is for the safety of our people. I wish it did not have to come to this but an evil walks among us. You are all aware of that, that is why we are gathered here, on sacred Potemkin grounds. Evil manifests itself in many ways. It can even look like one of you.
(pause)
All of you are here for a reason. There is potential in this group to restore goodness to our world, I believe in it. Do not fall for what sinners will tell you. They do not understand the work we are doing. I have lost too many brothers, sisters, and even children to the sin.
(sighing)
We lost our own Annie last month; she had just gotten engaged. I'm sure you all miss her dearly.
(pause)
Let's begin.

Joan gulps. Father Joseph digs roughly into a chalice with the Potemkin symbol carved on it, pulling out a folded paper. Joan holds her breath.

FATHER JOSEPH
Joan.

All eyes land on her. Even the new girl whom Joan sat next to looks worried. Shakily, Joan approaches Father Joseph, hearing the whispers surrounding her.

FATHER JOSEPH
You will see some things. Don't fall for the temptations. You're a bright one, Joan. Capable of so many things.

Father Joseph hands Joan a peculiar looking red liquid. With hesitation, Joan brings it up to her lips. Finally, she takes a sip. It's not long before the effects begin to materialize. Joan's surroundings blur together until everything looks pointillized, a world according to Seurat. She finds herself in some other realm. Joan only blinks once when her surroundings change in an instant.

EXT. JOAN'S HOUSE - DAY

Joan is standing outside of a run-down trailer park home. It almost resembles those trailers that actors use for makeup and resting in between scenes just only shittier. The grass outside is so overgrown that the stairs are barely visible. Joan approaches the mobile home slowly, reminding herself that this was only a test. She reaches for the door handle when BANG -- the door bursts open. A teenage girl runs out.

YOUNG JOAN
(echoing and distorted)
Don't even think of following me, mom. I don't care if you think I'm going to amount to nothing. There're people who are going to appreciate me somewhere. Wherever they are --it's not here.

The words overlap themselves as if underwater. JOAN'S MOM, 40s, stands at the door, disheveled with a bottle of vodka in her hand.

JOAN'S MOM
(slurring)
Wasn't even considering it. Trust me, there's not a single person in the world who would even look at you, you ungrateful brat.

Young Joan stops at her tracks and turns around.

YOUNG JOAN
Ungrateful? What have you done that makes a single difference in my life? You think I'm going to amount to nothing? Take a look at a god-damn mirror. You're an addict who failed as a mother. And maybe I failed as a daughter, but at least I'm willing to take a risk. You just drink. Sleep. Then drink again. I'm done. Have fun dying alone. At least I'll have people at my funeral.

She turns back and runs until she is out of sight. The scene playing out in front of Joan is all too familiar. Yet she cannot understand why. The figures are unrecognizable to her, as if her eyes are rejecting it like how they did with the girl in her dreams.

She tries to back away when without warning, she finds herself standing in a different place. Her hands, strangely smoother and her hair longer. She's taken that person's place. She has no time to think when the older figure appears in front of Joan.

JOAN'S MOM
Joanie. I'm sorry for what I said to you. I was struggling, kiddo.

JOAN
What?

JOAN'S MOM
Please, darling. Come back to me. I can change, I promise.

Joan backs up. Her mom continues to move closer, clearly not understanding personal space. Joan can't wrap her head around this. This was her mother? Why couldn't she... why couldn't she remember what she looked like?

JOAN'S MOM
Please. Please, Joanie. Please. Give me a hug, please.

JOAN
(stuttering)
No. This isn't real.

In an instant, the figure in front of her contorts, her face peeling like hangnails. Joan's right foot becomes stuck in mud, the ground rapidly decaying and rotting under her. She quickly pulls it out, steadying herself against the uneven soil. The grotesque creature in front of her lunges at her, but she quickly dodges. She doesn't hesitate to run. Though, she doesn't make it far when she slips and starts to fall backwards.

CUT TO:

EXT. FIELD - DAY

Joan lands in the middle of a grassy field. She looks around and it really is just field and field for miles. Out of the corner of her eye, she sees two silhouettes in the distance.

A young Joan and Essie lay on a grassy field seemingly in the middle of nowhere. The two giggle as they stare at the cloudy sky. It's not long before Essie breaks the silence.

YOUNG ESSIE
I could do this forever.

YOUNG JOAN
What? Looking at the sky until the sun finally aligns with your pupils and slowly burns away your vision.

YOUNG ESSIE
(laughing)
Precisely.

YOUNG JOAN
Really?

YOUNG ESSIE
No, of course not. I mean, just laying here, doing nothing. No worries. No expectations.

Essie turns her head to look at Joan. She stares at her for a second too long and looks away, flustered. Joan doesn't notice.

YOUNG ESSIE
Hey Joan?

YOUNG JOAN
Yeah?

YOUNG ESSIE
Do you think you'll ever get married? Settle down. Have a family.

Their eyes meet. Joan smiles.

YOUNG JOAN
Maybe, when I find the right person.

YOUNG ESSIE
Yeah.

Essie looks back at the sky and lets out a long sigh.

YOUNG JOAN
What is it?

YOUNG ESSIE
I don’t think the world is built for someone like me.

YOUNG JOAN
Oh, come on. Whoever gets to marry you would be the luckiest person in the world. They'll get to eat the best banana french toast every morning.

Essie laughs.

YOUNG JOAN
They'll also get to go on spontaneous trips.
(thinks)
Remember when you decided we should drive down to the Penobscot River because you were "over" having to clock in for your shift at Appalachian Trail? You could've just called in sick, or I don't know, quit?

YOUNG ESSIE
And you could've said no to coming.

A moment passes before Essie continues.

YOUNG ESSIE
(softly)
I loved that day.

YOUNG JOAN
Me too.

Joan is still standing from a distance but from somewhere inside her body, she feels something. It's not something she fully understands. It feels close. And warm. Yeah, that's how she would describe it.

Time stands still. Young Essie and Joan are no longer moving. Joan finds herself involuntarily moving towards them, and when she is close enough, her brain finally registers it. The memory.

Essie.

YOUNG ESSIE
Hey, Joan.

Joan's eyes open and her back is on the grass.

JOAN
(whispering)
Essie?

Tears run down Joan's face. She remembers everything. It is so clear to her now. Joan turns her head away from Essie in shame.

YOUNG ESSIE
What's wrong, Joan?

JOAN
I'm sorry I forgot.

YOUNG ESSIE
It's not your fault. What else could you have done?

JOAN
I could've gone with you.

Essie is silent. Joan faces her, so close that their noses are almost touching.

YOUNG ESSIE
(quietly)
What's done is done.

JOAN
No. No, I can change my future. That's why I left in the first place. Maybe, I ended up in the wrong place. But there's still time.

YOUNG ESSIE
Don't try to leave, Joan.

JOAN
What?

YOUNG ESSIE
Don't leave.

JOAN
Then how can I see you again? How do I get back to you?

Essie shakes her head. A stream of tears flows down her face and she bites her lip, trying to contain her raw emotion. Joan bolts upright and reaches her hand out to Essie's.

JOAN
No, Essie. I know you're just saying that because it's what's programmed in this hallucinatory dream-scape hell-hole.

(frustrated)
What the hell was in that drink?

Joan stands up, pulling Essie with her.

JOAN
Come on. We're getting out together.

YOUNG ESSIE
That's not how this works; I'm not really here.

JOAN
(crying)
It doesn't matter. This might be the last time I ever get to see you, why shouldn't I at least try to do something?

YOUNG ESSIE
You can't do everything, Joan. Some things are just out of your hands.

Essie starts to flicker in and out of existence, slowing fading like a hologram. Around them, the vast landscape also begins to crumble. It shouldn't be possible but even the sky is deteriorating, pieces of clouds start plummeting toward the ground.

YOUNG ESSIE
Do you remember what we promised?

Joan looks at Essie with her inner brows raised, desperate. Then, she smiles gently.

JOAN
If we were still single in our forties, we'd get married.

Essie's figure is still wavering, but she uses her strength to grin.

YOUNG ESSIE
Yes.

The sky continues to collapse on itself. Joan pulls Essie into a tight embrace. Essie leans into her touch.

JOAN
It was good to see you, Essie.

YOUNG ESSIE
(whispering)

Goodbye, Joan.

A piece of the sun plunges toward the two. But, before it can make contact, Joan pulls Essie into a deep kiss. It didn't matter that the world was ending before them. They had each other and that was enough. A blazing light shines over them and obstructs their bodies from view. Finally, the world caves in on them.

EXT. FATHER JOSEPH'S OFFICE/CONFESSIONAL ROOM - NIGHT

Joan jolts awake, finding herself in the confessional room. Across from her, Father Joseph sits in a chair. He looks a little too curious.

FATHER JOSEPH
What did you see, Joan?

Joan should be careful with her words. But at this point, it didn't matter to her. She needed to get the hell out of there.

JOAN
How long?

FATHER JOSEPH
I'm sorry?

JOAN
How long have you been doing this?

Father Joseph walks over and holds his hand out to move loose strands of hair from her face. Joan flinches like he had just tried to punch her.

JOAN
Get away! Don't touch me! How do you do it? Make us forget?
(thinks)
Do you poison the food? Or were we just easy targets and we fell for your promises?

FATHER JOSEPH
I keep my promises. It seems that you did not. I'm sorry, Joan.

Father Joseph opens the door and yells at the top of his lungs.

FATHER JOSEPH
JOAN HAS FAILED THE SACREST.

Joan quickly rises to her feet. Multiple people rush in at her, but she stealthily avoids and bolts past them through the door.

Joan trudges into the deep dark, unable to see anything. One wrong step and she'll go tumbling. The yelling behind her eventually grows distant. She sees it. The road. Suddenly, someone tackles her. It's Paris, with a face of determination and grip of hell.

JOAN
Get off me! Everything here is a lie.

PARIS
You don't know anything. It doesn't matter if it was all a lie. At least we have a place to live.
(grunting)
A place to call home. Not all of us had someone to go to, when we needed it most, Joan. You don't get to just leave.

JOAN
(reeling)
You're delusional if you think this is a home. This is hell! Do you even remember who you were before you came here?

PARIS
I did. During the test, but not anymore.

This pushes Joan over the edge. She cannot take it anymore. With a powerful strike, Joan's fist collides with Paris's skull, knocking her out. She uses this opportunity to get away. It hurts to run; she must've broken something when she was tackled.

She tries to limp over as fast as she can.

She is so close.

So close to freedom.

So close to her.

JOAN
(whimpering)
Essie! I'll see you soon.

Suddenly, Joan is pulled back, this time by multiple hands. Everyone has caught up to her -- her leg really slowed her down.

JOAN
(hysterical)

NO! ESSIE!

The camera pans alongside the struggle. It's not looking good; Joan is only moving further from the road. Bushes block our vision as Joan attempts to break free. The sound of dirt being kicked and bodies grappling each other are thunderous.

Finally, from out of frame and with a loud crunch, a blood curdling scream can be heard.

Joan's.

SLOW FADE TO:

INT. CHURCH - NIGHT

An aged Essie stands at a church altar, holding a newspaper in her hands. The front-page reads '20 YEARS SINCE CULT DISCOVERED IN MILLINOCKET.' Beside her feet is a lone candle, the only light source in the room. Essie fidgets with something beneath the newspaper, it's a folded paper.

ESSIE

If I had known you had joined a cult that was literally a thirty minute drive from my house, I would've tried to find you. I'm sorry you went there before you came to me. I should've tried harder to help you. Most importantly, Joan, I'm sorry I never got to tell you how much you meant to me. I never forgot about our promise. I wish you were here in front of me so I could say these words to you.

Essie unwraps the paper.

ESSIE
"I wish to marry you with no hesitation or doubt, and my commitment to you is absolute."
(laughing)
I stole that from the internet. You probably would've done the same thing. Joan Ward, do you take me to be your lawfully wedded wife?

It is so quiet inside that Essie's breathing reverberates through the room. She waits for a second as if she is waiting for a response. A response she knows she'll never get to hear. She begins to cry softly to herself. Her candle flickers as a sudden swift of ventilation enters the building. There is a shift in energy, perhaps more like a surge. Amid all of this, Essie thinks she hears something. Though she assumes it to be in her head, she's only been hearing her own thoughts from the moment she stepped on the altar.

When she turns to leave, she hears it.

JOAN (O.S.)
(in a low whisper)
I do.

The candle goes out.

FADE OUT.

THE END.